



Spanish Language and Literature I · 1st year of Bachillerato · How we understand each other · Class 1 of 7 · With Vera

Got the time?



Class video: <https://youtu.be/gilM9dhYTnw>

The code leads to the video.

Name: _____ Date: _____

The class is about Spanish, so the examples stay in Spanish, with their meaning in English in brackets.

Before you start

1. Someone in the street asks you «¿Tienes hora?» ("Have you got the time?"). You answer «Sí» ("Yes") and walk on. Did you answer well? Why? Answer in one sentence.
2. **At the end of the class.** Reread your answer. Would you change it? Write it again using the new words from the class: meaning, sense, inference, cooperation.

While you watch the video

1. What are the elements of communication? Write them down before Vera says them.

2. **Your prediction.** «¿Vienes a la fiesta del sábado?» — «Tengo examen el lunes» ("Are you coming to the party on Saturday?" — "I've got an exam on Monday"). Is that a yes or a no? Which words in the answer are you relying on?

3. In the conversation about the fries, what does the first girl say? What does her friend understand? How do you know?

4. «Algunos elefantes son mamíferos» ("Some elephants are mammals"). True or false? **Your prediction:** with less time to answer, will there be more "true" or more "false" responses? Why?

5. The reference letter: what does it say about the student as a philosopher? And what does it communicate?

What is said and what is communicated

Utterance	What the words say	What it communicates	How do I know?
«¿Tienes hora?» ("Have you got the time?")			
«Tengo examen el lunes» ("I've got an exam on Monday")			
«¡Ay! Yo no pedí patatas» ("Oh! I didn't order fries")			
The teacher's letter			
«Es un buen amigo» ("He's a fine friend")			
«Ningún detergente lava más blanco que este» ("No detergent washes whiter than this one")			

«¡Ay! Yo no pedí patatas» is a real sentence, from a conversation in the ESLORA corpus (University of Santiago de Compostela, <http://eslora.usc.es>), under a CC BY-NC 4.0 licence. The letter and «Es un buen amigo» are Paul Grice's examples (the second, adapted). The rest are invented.

The cancellation test

Add to each sentence a «pero...» ("but...") or a «de hecho...» ("in fact...") that denies what is understood, and read it aloud. Do you contradict yourself (**C**) or does it sound normal (**N**)? If it sounds normal, it was not in the words: it was an implicature.

1. «Tengo examen el lunes.» ("I've got an exam on Monday.") Understood: I'm not going to the party.
2. «He hecho algunos ejercicios.» ("I've done some of the exercises.") Understood: I haven't done them all.
3. «He aprobado todas las asignaturas.» ("I've passed all my subjects.") Understood: I've passed Language.
4. «Las palomitas estaban buenísimas.» ("The popcorn was great." You were asked how the film was.) Understood: I didn't like the film.
5. «Ningún detergente lava más blanco que este.» ("No detergent washes whiter than this one.") Understood: this one washes whiter than the others.
6. «Mi hermano está soltero.» ("My brother is single.") Understood: he isn't married.

One sentence, four situations

The sentence is always the same: «Son las once» ("It's eleven o'clock").

Situation	What does it communicate?	What do both people know that makes it understandable?
Someone has asked you the time in the street, and you answer		
Your mother, as you walk in (you had agreed to be back by ten)		
A student, to her teacher (the class was due to end at eleven)		
Another situation, invented by you:		

Practice

1. «¿Qué tal el examen?» — «La letra me salió preciosa» ("How did the exam go?" — "My handwriting came out lovely"). What does that answer communicate? Which of Grice's categories does it fail, one or more, and why?
2. «Me he comido algunas galletas» and «Me he comido todas las galletas» ("I've eaten some of the biscuits" and "I've eaten all the biscuits"). In each sentence, what else do you understand? Can you cancel it? Write out the test.

3. Find among your messages one of your own whose sense is not in its words. Write what it says and what it communicates. Only messages written by you: there is no need to show the conversation or say who you were writing to.

Keep thinking

If someone makes you believe something false by saying only true things, have they lied to you?

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